

Parasnath.—South of the Himalayas the highest mountain for many hundred miles is Parasnath Hill. It is situated in Hazaribagh district, not far from the boundary of Manbhum and is 4,481 feet high, the effect of this elevation being accentuated by its comparative isolation and the beauty of its form. It rises immediately north of the Grand Trunk Road at about the 200th mile and has been easily accessible ever since the construction of that road in 1838. Formerly, however, the route from the north and west led from Patna and Nawada through Kharagdiha to Palganj whilst travellers from the south and east came by the road which led from Jaipur in Manbhum through Nawagarh to Palganj. As both these roads led through wild Ghatwal tracts, which were not reduced to any semblance of order before the arrival of the British about 1770 a pilgrimage to Parasnath must have been costly and dangerous. It is much to be regretted that there is no account of such a journey and it is significant that the oldest of the temples appears to date only from A. D. 1765. In 1780 the new military road to Benares was made and brought travellers within sight of Parasnath "from Bankura to Kathamsanri" and an interesting account of a visit paid in 1827 is reproduced in the "Statistical Account". In 1871 the railway to Giridih was opened and there was left a gap of nineteen miles only to be covered by road across the Barakar river to Madhuban at the northern base of the hill. Finally the Grand Chord Railway brought pilgrims to the very foot of the sacred mountain and in the season from December to March a motor service connects Isri station with the temples at Madhuban. Visitors can halt at Dumri Bungalow, a mile from Isri, where food and lodging are obtainable. They can make arrangements there for climbing the hill up its steep southern face; or they can proceed ten miles down the provincial road towards Giridih, whence another three miles of good road (branching off at mile 16) brings them to Madhuban and the hill can be climbed on its easier northern side. A good path suitable for a pony or a *dandy* leads to a dak bungalow on the summit, where there is ample accommodation and furniture, but not food, water or servants, for which visitors must make their own provisions. The nearest spring is at considerable distance from the town. The hill commands magnificent views and is comparatively cool; but the absence of any level ground at the top is a great drawback and it is difficult to obtain supplies cheaply.

Dr. Hooker, who ascended the hill in February, 1848, writes thus of the view of Parasnath from near Taldanga in Manbhum :—

"As the sun rose Parasnath appeared against the clear grey in the form of a beautiful broad cone, with a rugged peak of a deeper grey than the sky. It is a remarkably

handsome mountain, sufficiently lofty to be imposing, rising out of an elevated country, the slope of which upward to the base of the mountain, though imperceptible, is really considerable; and it is surrounded by lesser hills of just sufficient elevation to set it off. The atmosphere, too, of these regions, is peculiarly favourable for views; it is very dry at this season, but still the hills are clearly defined, without the harsh outline so characteristic of a moist air. The skies are bright, the sun powerful; and there is an almost imperceptible haze that seems to soften the landscape, and keeps every object in true perspective. "

The view from the hill itself he describes as follows:—

" The view from the saddle of the crest was beautiful, but the atmosphere too hazy. To the north were ranges of low wooded hills, and the course of the Barakar and Ajay rivers, to the south lay a flatter country with lower ranges, and the Damodar river, its all but waterless bed snowy white from the exposed granite blocks with which its course is strewn. East and west the several sharp ridges of the mountain itself are seen; the western considerably the highest. Immediately below, the mountain flanks appear clothed with impenetrable forest, here and there interrupted by rocky eminences, while to the south the Grand Trunk Road shoots across the plains, like a white thread as straight as an arrow, spanning here and there the beds of the mountain torrents. "

Portions of the hill have been variously used since the British occupation of the district as a sanatorium for British troops but the confined space and absence of water made it unsuitable for such use. According to the version of the Jains when construction of sanatorium started they lodged an emphatic protest with the Government of India on the ground that the sacredness of the hill was likely to be violated which would offend the sentiments of the Jains. Accordingly the idea of establishment of a sanatorium was abandoned not merely because of confined space and absence of water but in respect of the sentiments of Jain, and the building which was constructed was later utilised as Dak Bungalow.

Parasnath is the " Marang Buru " or hill deity of the Santals of Hazaribagh, Manbhum, Bankura and Santal Parganas and each year they assemble at the period of the full moon in Baisakh from those

districts and celebrate a religious hunt for three days; after which a great tribal session is held for the trial of charges against *manjhis* and *parganaitis* and of other grave matters which effect the outcasting of individuals. The entry of this custom in the record-of-rights which was prepared in 1911 and of the similar right of the Ghatwars was followed by the institution of a suit by the Svetamber Jains to have it declared that no such custom exists. That suit was dismissed by the Judicial Commissioner and an appeal, preferred against his order, has been rejected by the High Court. The case went up to the Privy Council and it was held that the Santals have the customary right of hunting on the Parasnath Hill.

The special sanctity of Parasnath for the Jains arises from the tradition that the twenty-third of the Tirthankaras (the religious saints who are the objects of their worship), Parsva or Parsvanath, like nine of his predecessors, attained *nirvana* on the hill. According to the local tradition the number of Tirthankaras who attained *nirvana* on the Parasnath Hill is 20 and not 9. For each of them there is a shrine (*gumti for tuk*) on the hill. It is said that he was born at Benares and died at the age of one hundred years when fasting, along with thirty companions. He is usually depicted with a blue complexion and his cognizance is a hooded snake.

The foundation of Jainism is wrongly attributed by European scholars to the 24th and last Tirthankara, Vardhaman Mahavir, a contemporary of Buddha in the reign of King Bimbisara (about 519 B. C.), whose kingdom of Magadha then coincided with the limits of the modern districts of Patna and Gaya. Jainism was in existence from before and the 24th Tirthankara Mahabir gave a great fillip to its spread. Mahabir was related to the royal family, and spent many years of his ministry in that kingdom, where he gathered a large following of monks who afterwards spread his teaching over the greater part of India. At the present time the majority of the Jains belong to western India; and a large proportion of the Marwari traders who are to be found in every centre of trade belong to one or other of the Jain sects.

The two most prominent of these sects are the Svetambaras and Digambaras. The word Digambara means 'sky-clad', an euphemism for nude; and apparently their habit of taking their food naked, and refusing to decorate the image in their temples with any kind of ornament, are survivals of a wider practice, to which they owe their name. The Svetambaras or 'white-clad' on the other hand take their meals clothed and adorn the images of the Tirthankaras with a profusion of golden ornaments. They admit that women can obtain

nirvana and they hold that an ascetic should use a face cloth to guard the mouth and a brush for sweeping away insects, differing in all these matters from the Digambaras. At present they control the ceremonial at the temples and shrines on the hill and once the pilgrim has crossed the boundary just above Madhuban he must place himself in their hands, even though he be a Digambara. This has excited great bitterness between the sects, each of which is making strenuous attempts to obtain a more assured position on the hill. So far, the Svetambaras have had the greater success, for they have for some years enjoyed a lease by which they are entitled to build their shrines wherever they choose on the hill; but unfortunately for them the High Court declared the lease to be void. The matter was litigated again in Hazaribagh Courts and in the Patna High Court and ultimately a compromise has been arrived at. Now both the sects have freedom to worship at the temple without any hitch.

The old District Gazetteer of Hazaribagh states that "The hill is included in the old geographical division of Kharagdiha, and is shown in the map prepared by Rennell in 1779 as lying entirely within Palganj *gadi*. Recently, however, the owner of the Nawagarh *gadi* in Manbhum obtained a decree in a Civil Court that he was entitled to the southern face of the hill and the question is now on appeal before the High Court. A further complication in the present tangle has arisen out of a proposal made a few years ago to build houses for Europeans on the hill. The Jains disliked this and offered to buy the hill from the Encumbered Estates Department, which was at the time in charge of the estate of the Tikait of Palganj and the Digambaras claim that in the subsequent negotiations they were given a definite and enforceable promise of sale and this claim they are prosecuting by a civil suit. To add completeness to this maze of litigation which is financed by the subscriptions of the faithful throughout India the two sects have a suit pending between themselves regarding the manner of worship to be observed at the shrines on the hill".

The above may have been true at the time the District Gazetteer was last written. The hill was bought by the Jains from the Wards and Encumbered Estates, and the dispute with their owner of Nawagarh *gadi* in Manbhum was settled amicably long ago. There is at present no complication about any proposal to build houses for Europeans on the hills. Subsequently to the purchase of the hill by the Jains from the Wards and Encumbered Estates there arose differences between the trustees of the Digambaras and Svetambaras temples of the Jain as to be observed at the shrines on the hill. The dispute was decided in title suit by the High Court in favour of Svetambaras and

their trustees are in charge of the management of the hill. Recently under the Land Reforms Act the management of the hill was notified to be taken over by Government. The members of the Jain Community pressed their case for release of the hill from Government management on the ground that this would hurt the religious susceptibility of the Jains.

It has been stated above that the oldest date borne by any building is A. D. 1765, and it is believed that none of the edifices whether on or below the hill are of much earlier age. The pediment and a body of the temple were ornamented with arched entrances. The officers of the Archæological Department who have examined them have found nothing of special interest. The main building on the hill is a temple on the south-east side of the summit which was described in 1827 as follows :—

“ About three quarters of a mile on the southern descent from first *math* at which I arrived, and snugly sheltered from the northern and western storms, stands the principal and the most beautiful of all the temples in this neighbourhood. The same observation that I have made regarding the mixture of Musalman and Hindu architecture in the temples of Madhuban will apply to this *mandir*, which as I descended through the thick jungle upon it, looked more like a Muhammadan *dargah* than a building belonging to the original people of Hindustan. Government have deferred the actual taking over of the charge of the management of the hill and the representation of the Jaina is still under consideration. The pediment and body of the temple were ornamented with arched entrances between single pillars, such as are common in the larger houses of the Hindus; but above this all was in Muhammadan fashion. Five handsome fluted domes, one large one in the centre, surrounded with four small ones each forming the roof of a corresponding apartment, seemed too heavy a crown for the edifice from which they rose. These domes were well ornamented and were pointed with those spires composed of golden or brazen balls and ending in arrow heads, which are generally to be seen shooting out from the tops of minarets. The four sides of the building are alike, but to mark the principal approach, a large *chabutra* lies in front of the eastern archways.

On entering the centre and holy chamber of this temple it is impossible to avoid being impressed with the simple beauty of the place. The pavement is composed of fine slabs of blue veined marble and on a white marble pediment opposite to the entrance five very beautiful idols of the Jain Tirthankaras sit in dignity waiting for the prayers of their disciples, which are rendered more deep toned by the echoing influences of the domes that form the ceiling of the sanctuary. The centre figure, which represents Parasnath as a naked figure sitting cross-legged in an attitude of abstract meditation, is cut out of a beautiful piece of black marble. It measures between three and four feet high, as sitting and is remarkable graceful idol, in full preservation. The other four are each about two feet and a half high, all of them of white marble and one of them wearing the same hood which adorns the head of the central image, as the peculiar ornament of Parsvanath. On the pedestal of each idol the same inscription appears that Shuogal Chand Jagat Seth erected it in A. D. 1765. The chamber which constitutes this sanctuary is about twenty feet square and between thirty and forty feet high to the centre of the dome. There are no ornaments beyond those I have described, but the marble pavement, pedestal and idols are the handsomer for being unadorned. Of the four smaller apartments at the corner two remain empty and the other two contain each seventeen idols of all sizes (but all of the Jain form and posture) ranged along a ledge in the wall. These appear to have been left at will by pilgrims who may have been anxious to consecrate their household gods at the shrine of Parasnath ".

" It is held to be necessary that every *gumti* or *tuk* should be visited and receive an offering at the hands of each pilgrim and as many of the peaks are several *kos* distant from the *math* of Kuntnath to which the ascending path arrives, and as some of them can only be mounted by climbing, this is indeed a penance of extreme labour and fatigue. The length and tediousness of this duty is increased by their strict forbearance from committing any kind of impurity whatever within the holy precincts and as it is their custom to eat by day light only to

avoid incurring the destruction of the smallest insect. Several excursions to the summit are necessary for the accomplishment of the pilgrimage. Each *gumti* is a solid pile of brickwork, varying in height and size according to the facility its station afforded to the builders. The largest does not exceed eight feet in height and the same in length and breadth, while some appeared not to be larger than one-fourth of these dimensions. In each of the buildings is a small recess, on the flat of which is marked the print of a foot revered as the *charan* or last foot mark upon earth of the Tirthankara whose name is engraved beneath The visits and salutations to several *charans* on the peaks are concluded by a more deliberate adoration at the temple of Parsvanath. After concluding the duties on the mountain, those who desire to leave no claim to a sanctified character unadvanced perform a circuit round the base, starting from Madhuban, to which they again return traversing a circle of at least thirty miles. From this place the greater part of the pilgrims depart for the other temples at Pawapuri in Bihar and Champapuri near Bhagalpur." (Quoted in Lister's Hazaribagh Gazetteer.)

The highest peak of Parasnath is covered by a lofty pointed temple, which has replaced shrines, of which at least two had been successively destroyed by lightning. This temple is a conspicuous land-mark for many miles. There are two routes to Parasnath: (1) from Nimighat to top of Parasnath. One mile is motorable *pucca* road and 5 miles are a regular climb to the main temple; (2) from Madhuban $5\frac{3}{4}$ miles. After $2\frac{1}{2}$ miles there is a historic perennial stream which is called "Gandharva Nala". Further up there is another stream called "Sita Nala". The section of the hill from Madhuban to Gandharva Nala is not regarded as very sacred by the Jains. It is only the portion from Gandharva Nala up to the summit which is very sacred to Jains. On the way between Madhuban and Gandharva Nala "Phooly Bagan" is situated which is a settled estate in which tea used to be grown. The cultivation of tea has since been abandoned but the gardens are now being used as fruit orchard.

The administrative headquarters of the two sects are at Madhuban on the north side of the hill near the beginning of actual ascent. It is connected by a good road about three miles long, with one unbridged stream, with the provincial road which runs from Giridih to Dumri on

the Grand Trunk Road. The temple and rest houses of the two sects are congregated in the closest proximity and though none of the buildings appear to be of any antiquity, yet the collection of white-washed edifices, gay with flags and the golden ball of their cupolas, rising out of a green bed of their foliage is very beautiful when seen from the various stages of the ascent.

Peterbar.—It is at a distance of 12 miles from Gola. It has a fertile soil. Here rice is produced in abundance and it is a place for Government purchase during scarcity.

Rajrappa.—It is 9 miles from Gola. It has a temple of the goddess 'Chhinnamasta' at the confluence of the Damodar and the Bhera, a tributary to it. Persons from distant places come to this place to worship the goddess. Amidst hills and dense forests the river Damodar narrows down into a gorge and presents a beautiful sight. A big fair is held every year on vernal equinox (Pous Sankranti).

Raj Derwah.—Raj Derwah is a beauty spot. It is the centre of a National Park, a portion of reserved forest on the Hazaribagh-Barhi Road near Surajpura. The forest bungalow is about six miles from Hazaribagh-Barhi Road near about its 14th mile. Shooting is strictly prohibited here. The bungalow has two rooms with good accommodation but no arrangement for cooking food. There is no electricity. There is a water tower which commands an excellent view. This is an ideal picnic spot and visitors are advised to take their own provisions and lanterns.

Shilwar Hill.—Shilwar Hill is a beauty spot five miles from Hazaribagh town on the road to Bagodar. A number of old images have been found at this place. In 1953 a temple was constructed where the idols of Jagannath, Balbhadra and Subhadra have been installed and a *mela* has been started on Ratha Yatra day. The place is now named 'Jagannath Dham'. It is an ideal picnic spot although very close to the town.

Sitagarha.—It is at a distance of four miles east of the Hazaribagh town. It has got a good agricultural farm established and organised by a Christian Mission. At Sitagarha there is an agricultural school run by the Roman Catholic Mission and a Roman Catholic hospital known as Holy Family Hospital. There is also a branch of Calcutta Pinjrapole at Sitagarha where the *Gopastami Mela* is held on the 8th day of the bright-night of Kartik at every year. The arrangements are made by the local Marwaris, both Jains and Agarwals.